Lesson 42: Word Order

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 4: Words, Word Order and the Essay

Adapted from Building Academic Writing Skills by Lin Cui, Harper College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): Unit 19 Word Orders.

In this lesson

You learn the usual order of words in English sentences: the basic sentence patterns, time and place expressions, frequency words (always, often, every week), several adjectives before a noun, and embedded questions. The texts are about online courses (MOOCs), a baby's room and a pet dog. Correct word order makes your academic sentences sound natural and clear.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Write sentences with the three basic word orders.
- Put time and place expressions in the right order and position.
- Place one-word frequency adverbs and longer frequency expressions correctly.
- Put two or more adjectives in the right order before a noun.
- Write embedded questions with the order question word + subject + verb.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
word order	the arrangement (sequence) of words in a sentence	MOOCs are always online.
direct object / indirect object	the thing that receives the action / the person who receives the thing	My friends gave **my sister and me** (indirect) **some information on MOOCs** (direct).
subject complement	a word or phrase after a linking verb (be, grow…) that describes the subject	MOOCs are **self-paced**.
frequency word	a word or expression that tells how often	always, seldom, every day, twice a year
helping verb	a verb used with the main verb (be, have, do, will, can…)	Many students **had** never taken an online class.
embedded question	a question inside a sentence or inside another question	Do you know **who my child's teacher is**?
MOOC	Massive Open Online Course	MOOCs cover different areas.
self-paced	learning at one's own speed	MOOCs are self-paced.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
fundamentals	basics	Fundamentals of Accounting
in succession	one after another	more than one adjective in succession
embedded	located in the middle of something	an embedded question
parade	a large public procession to celebrate an important event, usually with music	a parade, a party, a ceremony

Rules and explanations

Basic word orders

- subject + verb + direct object: "Many world-class universities offer MOOCs."
- subject + verb + indirect object + direct object: "The information showed us the courses in computer science."
- subject + linking verb + subject complement: "MOOCs are open and free to everyone." "They have grown more and more popular."

Time and place

- Time and place words go at the beginning or at the end of a sentence: "Next week, my friend and I are starting a new MOOC course in Spanish." / "We are starting a new MOOC course in Spanish next week."
- Go from the smaller unit to the larger one: "in January 2021" (month before year); "the Metropolitan Autonomous University in Mexico" (university before country).
- With both, place usually comes before time: "We are starting our Spanish MOOC course from the Metropolitan Autonomous University in Mexico next week." Or put one at the beginning and the other at the end: "Next week, we are starting our Spanish MOOC course from the Metropolitan Autonomous University in Mexico."

Frequency words

Frequency word	Beginning	Middle	End
always	no	yes	no
usually	yes	yes	no
often	no	yes	yes
frequently, sometimes, occasionally	yes	yes	yes
seldom, rarely, never	yes, with a helping verb before the subject	yes	no
every day, every other week, once every three months, twice a year	yes	no	yes

- **Middle** means: before a "do" verb (an action verb), after a "be" verb, or between a helping verb and the main verb. "Students **always** like to take interesting online classes." "MOOCs are **often** more convenient than in-person classes." "Many students had **never** taken an online class before the Covid19 pandemic."
- "Frequently, sometimes, occasionally" can go anywhere: "Some of my friends take MOOCs **occasionally**."
- "Seldom, rarely, never" at the beginning need a helping verb before the subject: "**Seldom do** full time students take extra courses outside of their college."
- Expressions of two or more words go at the beginning or the end, not in the middle: "Some MOOCs are offered **several times a year**." "**Every week**, students study for certain hours."

Order of adjectives

When two or more adjectives come before a noun, use this order:

Order	Type	Examples
1	determiner	a, the, many, my, several, one
2	opinion	useful, difficult, friendly
3	size	big, short, small
4	age	1-year-old, old, young
5	shape	oval, round, square
6	color	blue, green, red
7	origin	American, Colombian, Turkish
8	religion	Catholic, Hindu, Islamic
9	material	cotton, silk, wooden
10	purpose	hiking (boots), picnic (table)
11	noun as adjective	grocery (store), kitchen (sink)

- Right: a beautiful, quiet room (not "a quiet, beautiful room"); a square, cotton blanket (not "a cotton, square blanket").

Embedded questions

In a question inside a sentence or inside another question, do not use question order. Use: question word + subject + verb.

- Wrong: We would like to know where is the childcare center. Right: We would like to know where **the childcare center is**.
- Wrong: Could you tell us which room should my child go to? Right: Could you tell us which room **my child should go** to?

- "How many children are there in one class?" (direct question) → "The teacher has not told us how many children **there are** in one class." (embedded question)

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - In Arabic, adjectives come after the noun. In English, adjectives come before the noun ("different areas", not "areas different"), and two or more adjectives follow the order in the table ("small red ants").

Practice

Exercise 1. True or false? Is the word order correct? Write True or False, and correct the false sentences.

1. I took **a few years ago** several MOOC courses in sociology and psychology.
2. They were offered **by universities in England and Australia.**
3. Always I chose the free classes.
4. For each course, I **two times a week** studied in the evening for two hours.
5. I usually read everything in the course, but I participated **seldom** in online discussions.
6. The quizzes and exams **often** consisted of multiple choice questions, so fortunately I did not need to write essays.
7. I **never** have taken a science course because I am not good at science.
8. However, maybe I should try one **sometimes**. Who knows? I may come to like science.

Exercise 3. Order of adjectives. Put the words in the right order to describe a baby and his room.

1. The baby has _____. (black / curly / hair)
2. There is a _____ on the wall in the baby's room. (frame / metal / photo / rectangular)
3. Against the opposite wall, there is an _____. (dresser / elegant / tall)
4. Several _____ are on the floor in the corner of the room. (animals / brown / lovely / stuffed)
5. The baby's _____ always likes to watch the baby and hum a lullaby as he sleeps. (grandma / gray-haired / sweet)

Exercise 4. Embedded questions. Choose the correct word order (sentences about a day care center).

1. The parents are trying to find out _____. a) what time the parents can meet the teacher b) what time can the parents meet the teacher
2. The parents want to know _____. a) what volunteer work they can do there b) what volunteer work can they do there
3. The teacher is asking _____. a) what time the parents are available to help b) what time are the parents available to help
4. One of the teachers is trying to find out _____. a) why is little Mia absent b) why little Mia is absent

5. The kids are wondering _____. a) when is their snack time b) when their snack time is

Exercise 5. Put the words in order. Sentences about a pet dog.

Example: friend, Teddy, dog, good, my, pet, is → My pet dog Teddy is my good friend.

1. He is a _____. (brown / German / large / Shepherd)
2. Teddy _____ wags his _____ tail when he sees me. (always) (beautiful / long)
3. He may be asking me _____. (food / his / is / where)
4. He _____. (frequently / hungry / is)
5. I _____ him _____. (feed / four times a day / usually)
6. _____ I tell Teddy _____. (Every day / how / I / spend my day)
7. I hope he _____. (always / me / stay / will / with)

Exercise 6. Puppies in Love. Write the two words in the right order (from the story of Shiro in the lesson material).

Example: The story happened on a **small Japanese** (Japanese, small) island Aka in the 1980s.

1. It _____ _____ (usually, happened) in the morning, but ...
2. ... but _____ _____ (always, he) came back at night.
3. He _____ _____ (always, was) wet when he returned.
4. They wanted to find out where _____ _____ (went, Shiro).
5. Mr. Nakamura jumped onto his _____ _____ (little, fishing) boat and followed him.
6. Shiro ... walked to a _____ _____ (wooden, beautiful) house.
7. He started to play with a _____ _____ (lovely, small) puppy there.
8. After the Nakamuras moved, Shiro _____ _____ (visited, frequently) his girlfriend puppy.
9. They wondered how long _____ _____ (Shiro, swam).

Speak with your tutor

- "Check my answers to the Pretest in the lesson material and explain each mistake."
- "Ask me ten 'How often do you ...?' questions about my study habits. I will answer with frequency words. Correct their position."
- "Ask me five direct questions about my university. I will change each one into an embedded question, starting with 'Do you know ...' or 'Could you tell me ...'. Check my word order."
- "I will describe five things in my room with two or three adjectives each. Check the order of my adjectives."
- "I looked at one of the online courses in Exercise 2 of the lesson material. Ask me whether I would take it and why, and correct my word order."

Read aloud

- MOOCs are always online.
- Students spend about two to three hours every week.
- Many students had never taken an online class before the Covid19 pandemic.
- Seldom do full time students take extra courses outside of their college.
- He is a large, brown German Shepherd.
- Could you tell us which room my child should go to?
- We would like to know where the childcare center is.

Writing task

Write a descriptive paragraph of 150 to 200 words on one topic from Exercise 7:

- Whom do you love the most? Describe him or her.
- What is the best gift you have received? Describe it.
- Which is your favorite room in your house or apartment? Describe it.
- What has been the most exciting scene you have seen (for example, a parade, a party, a ceremony)? Describe it.

Include a title, a topic sentence, supporting details and a concluding sentence. Use at least three nouns with two or more adjectives, four frequency words (at least one one-word adverb in the middle and one expression of two or more words), one sentence with both a place and a time, and one embedded question ("I still do not know how she found it").

Self-editing checklist:

- Every sentence has subject + verb (+ object or complement) in the usual order.
- Place comes before time; smaller units come before larger units.
- One-word frequency adverbs are before a "do" verb, after "be", or between a helping verb and the main verb.
- Frequency expressions of two or more words are at the beginning or the end.
- Adjectives come before the noun, in the order opinion, size, age, shape, color, origin, material, purpose.
- Embedded questions use question word + subject + verb.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- MOOC.org, information about MOOCs (Exercise 2): https://www.mooc.org/
- Course #1, Writing and Editing: Structure and Organization: https://www.classcentral.com/course/writing-editing-structure-19554
- Course #2, Introduction to Classical Music: https://www.classcentral.com/course/introclassicalmusic-2987

- Course #5, Essentials of Global Health: https://www.classcentral.com/course/essentials-global-health-7337

Answer key

Exercise 1 (book: True / False)

1. False. I took several MOOC courses in sociology and psychology a few years ago. (Or: A few years ago, I took ...)
2. True.
3. False. I always chose the free classes.
4. False. For each course, I studied in the evening for two hours two times a week.
5. False. ... but I seldom participated in online discussions.
6. True.
7. False. I have never taken a science course because I am not good at science.
8. True. (The word order is correct. For the meaning "at some time in the future", "sometime", without -s, is more usual.)

Exercise 3 (book)

1. curly, black hair 2. rectangular, metal photo frame 3. elegant, tall dresser 4. lovely, brown, stuffed animals 5. sweet, gray-haired grandma

Exercise 4 (book)

1. a 2. a 3. a 4. b 5. b

Exercise 5 (book)

1. large, brown German Shepherd 2. always; beautiful, long 3. where his food is 4. is frequently hungry 5. usually feed; four times a day 6. Every day; how I spend my day 7. will always stay with me

Exercise 6 (book)

1. usually happened 2. he always 3. was always 4. Shiro went 5. little fishing 6. beautiful wooden 7. lovely small 8. frequently visited 9. Shiro swam

My notes